

The Lighthouse Keeper's Last Night

Old Marcus had kept the lighthouse on Cold Harbor Point for thirty-one years. Tonight, a letter from the coast guard sat unopened on his table, and he already knew what it said: the lighthouse was being automated, and his job was finished.

He climbed the spiral stairs one final time, boots echoing on iron steps he could have walked blind. At the top, the great lamp turned slowly, sweeping its beam across a dark and restless sea, just as it had every night since before his daughter was born.

A storm was building on the horizon, black clouds stacking like a wall. Marcus watched a small fishing boat fighting against the swells, its running lights barely visible through the spray. He had seen a hundred boats caught out like this before.

He made his choice without hesitation, radioing the coast guard with the boat's position before they could even ask. Then he stayed at the glass, keeping the light steady, guiding the little boat safely past the rocks and into the calm water of the harbor.

By morning, the storm had passed and the fishing boat's captain came to shake his hand, not knowing it was Marcus's last night on watch. Marcus smiled, said nothing about the letter, and simply pointed up at the lamp, still turning, still faithful, one more time.